



U N I V E R S I T Y O F T H E
CUMBERLANDS

GRADUATE SCHOOL DOCTORAL RESEARCH
HANDBOOK

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Introduction

Doctoral Program and Research Process

The Graduate School at the University of the Cumberland offers Doctor of Business Administration, Doctor of Education, and Doctor of Philosophy degrees. The doctoral research, designed to evaluate the candidate's capabilities as a scholar, is the final academic requirement of the DBA, EdD, and PhD programs. Candidates complete the doctoral research during professional research courses (DSRT 736, 839, 930, 931), which are the last four courses taken during the program. This handbook sets forth the guidelines for completing the dissertation or doctoral project process.

Purpose of the Handbook

The purpose of this handbook is to guide candidates through the doctoral research process, including developing the research, the oral defense, and final document submission. The handbook outlines candidate and committee member responsibilities, defines writing guidelines, identifies required sections for each chapter, and provides printing guidelines for the final dissertation document. The handbook is to be used by instructors, dissertation chairs, and committee members to ensure high standards related to the form and appearance of dissertations.

Doctoral Research Committee

Doctoral research committees are made up of three members, including the chair, and two committee members. Each member has specific responsibilities, as outlined below and must have current CITI Social and Behavioral Research training.

Choosing Committee Members

While enrolled in DSRT 930, the candidate and the chair will identify instructors to serve on his/her dissertation committee. The DSRT course instructor will serve as the chair. Other members are to be instructors teaching at the graduate level at the University of the

Cumberlands. These members should be chosen based on doctoral research topic expertise and candidate needs. The academic department will provide candidates with a list of instructors available to serve on committees. The committee member request form is submitted to the academic department, and any committee changes must be resubmitted to the academic department.

Committee Chair Responsibilities

Responsibilities of the committee chair include:

- Advising the candidate through the doctoral research process.
- Guiding the candidate in the selection of two additional committee members.
- Assisting the candidate in meeting deadlines for completion of the doctoral research.
- Assisting the candidate in navigating the IRB approval process.
- Guiding the candidate in achieving a high level of technical and ethical quality in doctoral research.
- Advising the candidate in the selection of methods/procedures for data collection and analysis.
- Advising the candidate in proper APA style.
- Determining when a document is ready for review by the committee and communicating such with committee members. The candidate should avoid consulting the full committee for feedback without prior approval of the chair.
- Determine when Chapters One, Two, Three, and Four are ready for quality review by the Graduate School.
- Determine when the full manuscript is ready for quality review by the Graduate School.
- Advising the candidate in preparation for the doctoral research defense.

- Submitting the defense scheduling request form to the academic department to schedule the date and time of all doctoral research defense meetings.
- Submitting the defense scoring rubric (see Appendix E) from committee members to the department chair promptly after the defense.
- Submitting a print-ready copy of the doctoral research to the department chair before the anticipated graduation date of the candidate.

Responsibilities of Other Committee Members

Responsibilities of other committee members include:

- Providing subject matter expertise as requested by the chair or candidate.
- Reading drafts and providing meaningful feedback.
- Corresponding with the chair and candidate as needed for clarification and resolution of methodological issues during the doctoral research process.
- Immediately notifying candidate and doctoral research chair when major flaws that are likely to result in a candidate's unsuccessful defense are identified.
- Participating in the defense and asking meaningful questions about the dissertation.
- Signing the signature page promptly.

Candidate Responsibilities

Responsibilities of the doctoral research candidate include:

- Coordinating with the chair to select committee members based on expertise in the doctoral research topic area. The candidate is encouraged to select at least one member as the methodologist with expertise in data collection and analysis. Another committee member should be a content expert in the dissertation topic.
- Completing the IRB process to obtain approval for research before recruiting subjects or collecting data.

- Choosing a topic, submitting proofread drafts of materials to the chair, preparing adequately for consultations, and communicating regularly with the chair.
- Contacting the chair in the event of any significant change in the personal or professional situation, which may interfere with program completion.
- Successfully defending research.
- Submitting an error-free, print-ready copy of the dissertation as a pdf document to the dissertation chair and the academic department promptly after a successful defense.

Doctoral Research Guidelines

Choosing a Research Topic

Candidates begin thinking about doctoral research topics when applying for admission to the program. The doctoral research topics must be grounded in theory, related to program goals, and have implications for practitioners. Candidates are encouraged to choose research topics of personal relevance and significance. When opportunities arise in coursework, candidates should begin researching these topics in the form of literature reviews and other assignments that allow for research. The research topic will be narrowed to a research study and approved by the department chair/director and subsequently, the Graduate School when candidates enroll in the first doctoral research course, DSRT 736.

Doctoral Research Timeline

Dissertation Seminar (DSRT 736)

Candidates submit the topic approval form in DSRT 736, and the academic department coordinates the topic approval process with the 736-course professor. Candidates complete the review of the literature (Chapter Two) while enrolled in DSRT 736. Completing DSRT 736 is a requirement for enrolling in DSRT 839. Candidates should complete the required CITI Social

and Behavioral Research training and submit the certificate with the IRB application in DSRT 839.

Advanced Research (DSRT 839)

While enrolled in DSRT 839, candidates complete Chapter One, the introduction to the dissertation or project, and Chapter Three, the methodology section. Candidates must apply for approval for their doctoral dissertation or project from the Institutional Review Board while enrolled in DSRT 839. IRB approval is required before collecting any data, recruiting participants, or developing the project. IRB approval is a requirement to pass DSRT 839 and proceed to DSRT 930.

Comprehensive Exams. During enrollment in DSRT 839, students complete their Comprehensive Exams. Through coordination with the Graduate School, Academic Departments provide study sessions, materials, and remediation as necessary. Students will sign up for the exams during designated testing windows. Passing the Comprehensive Exams is a requirement to pass DSRT 839 and proceed to DSRT 930. If a student fails the Comprehensive Exams, or a portion of the Comprehensive Exams, remediation is required and provided through the Graduate School and the Academic Department. A student must participate in remediation and sign up for a second attempt after two weeks of additional preparation. If a student fails the second attempt, then additional remediation is required. A student must participate in remediation and sign up for a final attempt after additional preparation. If a student fails the third attempt, then a grade of F is recorded for the DSRT 839 class, and the student may be dismissed from the doctoral program.

Dissertation Sequence (DSRT 930-931)

A completed Chapter One, Two, and Three are required before candidates enroll in DSRT 930. In 930, candidates complete Chapter Four, which presents their doctoral dissertation or project findings. While enrolled in DSRT 930, the dissertation is submitted to the Graduate School for a quality review. Once enrolled in DSRT 931, candidates complete Chapter Five. In Chapter Five, candidates interpret their findings, discuss implications of those findings, present recommendations for further study and action, and discuss how their study fills a gap in the literature and contributes to the field of study. The doctoral research committee reviews the full manuscript and provides meaningful feedback to ensure requirements are met. The committee and Graduate School Quality Review representative will recommend the doctoral dissertation or project for oral defense when it meets the Graduate School Guidelines. Candidates orally defend their doctoral research while enrolled in DSRT 931, which is the final step in the doctoral research process. After a successful defense, candidates submit a PDF of the approved dissertation or project with the signature sheet to the academic department. At that time, the Program Director recommends the candidates for graduation.

The DBA, EdD, and PhD programs are designed for dissertations or projects to be completed in four courses. Candidates needing additional time may enroll in additional courses providing the total time in the program does not exceed the degree time limit noted in the Graduate School catalog. Department chairs or Program Directors must approve repeated enrollment in DSRT 931.

Doctoral Research Probation Process

To protect the doctoral research timeline, the following probation process has been implemented. A “missed deadline” occurs when a student does not satisfactorily pass any dissertation course and is forced to repeat the course OR when a student does not complete the

dissertation or project in the prescribed timeline and begins taking additional courses toward degree completion (DSRT 931-R).

A student's progress will be assessed through the completion of assignments in dissertation courses and the dissertation progress rubric (see Appendix E). Scores of less than three (3) on the rubric in DSRT 930 and 931 demonstrate limited progress toward completing the dissertation. Students with scores less than three (3) will be supported through interventions, including developing written plans and goals for completion and follow-up by the student success coordinator, Program Director, and Graduate School.

1st missed deadline

Intervention:

- (1) The student will meet with the program director and develop a written plan and timelines to complete the dissertation. The plan and timelines will be reviewed at the end of the course to determine if progress was made, and goals were met.
- (2) The student will repeat failed course (if DSRT 736 or 839) or will enroll in DSRT 931-R (first time) and receive a probation letter from Academic Affairs.

2nd missed deadline

Intervention:

- (1) The student will meet with the program director to revise the written plan and timelines to complete the dissertation.
- (2) Escalate to Dean/Associate Dean of Graduate School, if needed.
- (3) The plan and timelines will be reviewed at the end of the course to determine if progress was made and if goals were met.
- (4) The student will repeat failed course (if DSRT 736 or 839) or will re-enroll in DSRT 931-R (second time) and receive a probation letter from Academic Affairs.

- (5) If Executive, student is prohibited from participating in CPT the following semester and placed on “subject to suspension.”

3rd missed deadline – Executive student is dismissed from the program

Intervention (applies to online students only):

- (1) The student will meet with the program director to revise the written plan and timelines to complete the dissertation.
- (2) The student submits monthly documentation to the Program Director and Graduate School about progress.
- (3) The plan and timelines will be reviewed monthly and at the end of the course to determine if progress was made and if goals were met.
- (4) Student receives a probation letter from Academic Affairs

Online student - may continue to enroll in DSRT 931-R until 6-year enrollment period ends. (All graduate programs must be completed within 6 years of initial enrollment- Graduate Catalog).

Executive student – dismissed from the program and receives a dismissal notice from Academic Affairs and Department of International Graduate Services.

Doctoral Research Style

Ultimately, the doctoral research will fall into one of the following broad outlines: a quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods study. The seventh edition of the Publication Manual of the American Psychological Association (APA) is the style manual to be used in writing the doctoral research. Candidates should follow all APA guidelines.

Doctoral students may choose between writing a doctoral dissertation following a quantitative, qualitative, or mixed-methods design, or developing a doctoral project following a quantitative applied research design (see Appendix F, G, H). Whether a traditional dissertation study or applied research project, both types of doctoral research are grounded in theory, related

to program goals, and have implications for practitioners. Candidates are encouraged to choose a dissertation or project topic of personal relevance and significance as well as aligned with the degree program of study.

The doctoral dissertation, a scholarly document, is written for professionals in the field. The research questions at hand primarily determine the dissertation style. For instance, a student may utilize an existing database to evaluate their hypotheses. Access to the database as originally published, is highly encouraged. Alternatively, they could build a novel testing or survey instrument to gather the data needed for their study. Another example may employ an in-depth comparative case study.

Quantitative Research

There are two options for quantitative research: A traditional five-chapter dissertation or Applied Research Project.

Traditional Five Chapter Quantitative Dissertation

The traditional quantitative dissertation follows a five-chapter format and a deductive approach. The required sections for the five chapters of the quantitative dissertation are located in Appendix A and in the dissertation template in the Doctoral Research site materials. While there is no set number of pages, quantitative research typically includes a minimum of 100 pages. This word requirement applies to the text of the dissertation only; it does not cover the title page, acknowledgments, table of contents, or other non-content related pages. The quantitative dissertation study will follow the conventions of an aligned quantitative research design (see Appendix F).

Applied Research: Doctoral Project

Students who select the doctoral project will follow the Applied Research Option. This design extends or applies research through the development of a doctoral project for the DBA,

EdD, and PhD programs. The applied research option, doctoral project, follows a four chapter format and may include software or IT tool development, business model, or educational program. The doctoral applied research project will use a systematic applied research approach to present a new tool, model, or program as determined through the literature review of existing items in the academic discipline. Candidates complete the Applied Research during professional research courses (DSRT 736, 839, 930, 931), which are the last four courses taken during the program (See Appendix B). There is no set number of pages due to the nature of the doctoral project, but a systematic applied research approach must be used (see Appendix G and the applied research dissertation template in the Doctoral Research site materials.).

Qualitative Dissertations

The qualitative dissertation should be approximately 45,000 words but must follow a systematic qualitative research approach (see Appendix H and the qualitative dissertation template in the Doctoral Research site materials.). This word count requirement applies to the text of the dissertation only; it does not cover the title page, acknowledgments, table of contents, or other non-content related pages. Thus, with a small indulgence in tautology, the dissertation should be as long as it needs to be, as long it meets the minimum word requirement and includes the appropriate chapter components (See Appendix C).

Mixed-Methods Dissertations

The Program Director must approve the mixed-methods dissertation methodology, and the dissertation committee will provide guidance and expertise on the formatting requirements for this type of dissertation (See Appendix C). The Program Director, dissertation chair, and/or committee will specify specific formatting guidelines for the mixed methods dissertation study following a five-chapter format.

Final Document

The final doctoral research document must be submitted while enrolled in the last research course, DSRT 931. After the successful oral defense, the candidates submit an error-free, print-ready copy of the final doctoral research documents. The final doctoral research must include all committee members and Graduate School Quality Control representative, recommended edits in the final pdf document. The copy is to be submitted electronically to the academic program. If a candidate would like bound doctoral research copies, then he or she may submit one printed copy (using white, 24 lb. résumé paper) of the doctoral research to the academic program office before the designated semester deadline. After having the copy bound, the UC Binding Department will return the copy to the candidate. If the candidate wishes to request more than one bound copy, he/she should submit the number desired. The Binding Department will bill the student for the additional copies at a minimal cost per copy.

Doctoral Research Approval Process

Approval for conducting doctoral research should be obtained while enrolled in DSRT 839 and is a pre-requisite to piloting, developing a project, or gathering research. The Institutional Review Board application to conduct research, and all supporting documents must be submitted to the IRB chair. Students should refer to the Doctoral Research site for forms, tutorials, examples, supporting materials, and links for IRB submission. The doctoral research chair will review and approve the document, and then the student should submit the documents in the dissertation portal. Candidates can download their IRB Approval Letter from the portal once the research has been approved. No research is to be executed until IRB approval is granted, and all necessary consents (adults) and assents (minors) are secured from participants. The IRB Approval Letter is to be placed in the doctoral research as Appendix A. Students should submit the IRB modifications/addendum application to request approval for any modifications to

the approved research procedures. Following the final QC review and approval to defend, students must submit the IRB Close-out form in the dissertation portal to notify the IRB that the research has concluded.

Human Subjects Research: Participant Sampling and Recruitment

The dissertation manuscript must include a description of the study target population, and a justification for the aligned sampling method to recruit human subjects that are representative of the study target population is required. Therefore, it is also essential that procedures for the recruitment of potential participants reflect inclusion/exclusion criteria, recruitment materials, and any third-party recruitment services including paid services. To ensure ethical and quality research, recruitment procedures must not include any procedures that can be inferred as coercive, misleading, unduly influential, or involve dual relationships between the principal investigator and potential participants. Recruitment is not permitted in research settings where the investigator has personal connections (such as family, friends, professional, or other social relationships) or in locations where the investigator holds a supervisory role over potential participants.

Site Authorization

A letter of site authorization, site permission, or letter of agreement is required from each research setting where participant recruitment will be conducted. This includes the primary organization that serves as the research setting. For example, if K12 principals from a particular state are the target population and sampling will occur with the state principals' association, a site authorization letter is needed from the association. Site authorization may be provided via a letter on the organization's letterhead or by email with the authorizer's role and organization included.

Social Media and Internet Recruitment

Recruitment that involves social media or other internet sites or services must clearly reflect the study's target population. Internet recruitment that involves paid services to sample participants must also meet the requirements for third-party paid recruitment services. A detailed description is required for how the recruitment process will ensure that potential participants reflect the target population. Site authorization is required for social media recruitment from closed groups (e.g., Facebook, LinkedIn, or others). If an open group is to be used, a detailed description of the group is required along with evidence that the site does not require permission to recruit. Recruitment is not permitted from social media or other internet accounts where the investigator has personal connections (such as family, friends, professional, or other social relationships) or the investigator holds a supervisory role over potential participants. Program Director approval for social media or internet recruitment may be required.

Third-Party Paid Recruitment Services

Third-party paid recruitment services may be used on a case-by-case basis (e.g., survey tools, internet mining services, self-testing tools, or others) for participant recruitment, as this form of recruitment is not appropriate for all types of research. Use of third-party recruitment services may potentially impact the validity of research as the exact identity of participants is not usually possible. The recruited sample through third-party paid recruitment may not be representative of the actual target population for the specific doctoral research study. A detailed description of the service, cost of the service, and recruitment procedure should be provided. The detailed recruitment procedural description must also supply assurances that potential participants recruited by the service will reflect the target population. This level of assurance will require additional inclusion of specific qualifications and inclusion/exclusion criteria to be set up

with the third-party recruitment service. Program Director approval may be required for third-party paid recruitment.

International Research

Research conducted using international sites or participants outside of the US requires additional steps for IRB approval. As countries have their own cultures and values, the Principal Investigator (PI) needs to understand the context of their research as it applies to international policies and procedures. As a result, the Principal Investigator acknowledges, understands, and plans the research to ensure the following is noted and documented:

The selection of subjects is equitable.

1. The research participants' privacy is protected, and the confidentiality of data is maintained.
2. Informed consent is sought in language understandable to the subject and under conditions that minimize the possibility of coercion or undue influence, and
3. Appropriate safeguards protect the rights and welfare of vulnerable subjects.

Publishing Guidelines

All doctoral research is subject to approval by UC's institutional review board. The dissertation chair guides the research throughout the doctoral research process. Students seeking publication of any portions of the dissertation or publications based on work completed during the dissertation process should obtain pre-approval from the dissertation chair and Program Director prior to submitting research for publication. The names of the chair or committee members on any publication associated with the dissertation are not permitted without permission and written consent.

Oral Defense

While enrolled in the final doctoral research course, candidates must present an oral defense of their dissertation or project. This oral defense is presented after the committee chair, and all committee members have given feedback, and all edits have been made to the doctoral research. The academic department will schedule the defense session after the Graduate School completes a Quality Review of the doctoral research (defense ready file). All three committee members must be present for the oral defense. The oral defense session normally takes 45-60 minutes. The committee members and chair ask questions and offer comments. The committee dismisses the candidate for committee deliberation. Once the committee and chair have deliberated and reached a decision, the candidate is invited to re-join the group for the committee decision. The committee makes one of the following decisions:

- approved with no revisions,
- approved with minor revisions,
- provisionally approved with major revisions, or
- not approved with the recommendation to write new doctoral research study or repeat the oral defense.

If one of the first two decisions is determined, the committee chair works with the candidate to get the final document ready to send to the department chair for review. If the committee decision requires major revisions or a new doctoral research study, the candidate enrolls in another research course to complete the revisions or rewrite. If the defense is to be repeated, the candidate prepares with the committee for a new defense. The defense must be successfully completed by the department defense deadline for the semester. The doctoral research chair and committee evaluate the candidate using the department rubric (see Appendix E).

Graduation

Candidates should apply for graduation at the beginning of the semester in which they plan to graduate. The information about applying for graduation is located at <https://www.ucumberlands.edu/academics/registrar>. Once the research has been successfully defended, and copies of the doctoral research are received by the department chair, then the department chair notifies the registrar that the candidate has completed all program requirements and is eligible to graduate. Commencement ceremonies are held in May. Candidates are hooded during the commencement.

Appendix A: Quantitative Dissertation (Traditional Five Chapter Format)

Title Page

Signature Page

Acknowledgments

Abstract

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List of Tables

Chapter One (Introduction) (DSRT 839)

Overview

Background and Problem Statement

Purpose of the Study

Significance of the Study

Research Questions

Theoretical Framework

Limitations of the Study

Assumptions

Definitions

Summary

Chapter Two (Review of Literature) (DSRT 736)

Introduction

Subsections based on a deductive approach

Summary

Chapter Three (Procedures and Methodology) (DSRT 839)

Introduction

Research Paradigm (quantitative)

Research Design

Sampling Procedures and or/

Data Collection Sources (reference Informed Consent and IRB approval placed in
Appendices)

Statistical Tests

Summary

Chapter Four (Research Findings) (DSRT 930)

Introduction

Participants and Research Setting

Analyses of Research Questions (one at a time)

Supplementary Findings (if any)

Summary

Chapter Five (Summary, Discussion, and Implications) (DSRT 931)

Introduction

Practical Assessment of Research Questions

Limitations of the Study

Implications for Future Study

Summary

References

Appendices (This section contains any tables, figures, and possible data sources that could not be placed in the text of the paper due to its size, as well as copies of consent forms and IRB letters).

Appendix B: Doctoral Project (Quantitative: Applied Research Format)

Title Page

Signature Page

Acknowledgments

Abstract

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List of Tables

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Chapter One (Introduction) (DSRT 839)

Overview

Background and Problem Statement

Purpose of the Project

Significance of the Project

Research Questions

Theoretical Framework

Limitations of the Project

Assumptions

Definitions

Summary

Chapter Two (Review of Literature) (DSRT 736)

Introduction

Subsections based on a deductive approach

Summary

Chapter Three (Procedures and Methodology) (DSRT 839)

Introduction

Research Paradigm (quantitative)

Research Project Design

Development Process

Population and Sampling Procedures

Data Collection Procedures

Development Data

Testing and Evaluation Data

Data Analysis Procedures

Development Results

Testing and Evaluation Results

Analyses of Research Questions (one at a time)

Supplementary Findings

Ethical Considerations

Summary

Chapter Four (Summary, Discussion, and Implications) (DSRT 930 and 931)

Introduction

Practical Assessment of Project Analysis (analysis of each research question and supplementary findings)

Limitations of the Study

Implications for Future Study

Summary

References

Appendices (This section contains any tables, figures and possible data sources that could not be placed in the text of the paper due to its size, as well as copies of consent forms and IRB letters.)

Appendix C: Qualitative Dissertation Format

Title Page

Signature Page

Acknowledgments

Abstract

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List of Tables

Chapter One (Introduction) (DSRT 839)

Overview

Background and Problem Statement

Purpose of the Project

Significance of the Project

Research Questions

Theoretical Framework

Limitations of the Project

Assumptions

Definitions

Summary

Chapter Two (Review of Literature) (DSRT 736)

Introduction

Subsections based on a deductive approach

Summary

Chapter Three (Procedures and Methodology) (DSRT 839)

Introduction

Research Method and Paradigmatic Perspective

Qualitative Research Approach

Name of Methodology

Trustworthiness

Role of the Researcher

Researcher Positionality

Reflexivity and Bracketing

Sampling Procedures and or/ Data Collection Sources (reference Informed Consent and IRB approval placed in Appendices) – Interviews, Surveys/Questionnaires, Document Analysis, Focus Groups, Observations,

Sampling Strategy

Instrument Development

Participant Recruitment

Data Collection

Data Saturation

Data Analysis

Data Preparation

Coding and Theme Development

Summary

Chapter Four (Research Findings) (DSRT 930)

Introduction

Participants and Research Setting

Study Analysis

Analyses of Research Questions (one at a time)

Supplementary Findings (if any)

Summary

Chapter Five (Summary, Discussion, and Implications) (DSRT 931)

Introduction

Practical Assessment of Research Questions

Limitations of the Study

Implications for Future Study

Summary

References

Appendices (This section contains any tables, figures and possible data sources that could not be placed in the text of the paper due to its size, as well as copies of consent forms and IRB letters.)

Appendix D: Qualitative (Historical) and Mixed Methods Dissertation Information

Title Page

Signature Page

Acknowledgments

Abstract

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Chapter One (DSRT 736)

Additional Chapters (DSRT 839, 930, 931)

References

Appendices

*Specific formatting guidelines will be specified by the Program Director, dissertation chair, and committee.

Appendix E:

Doctoral Research Evaluation Rubric

Criterion	4 (Expert)	3 (Proficient)	2 (Fair)	1 (Poor)
I. Critical and reflective thinking capable of facilitating institutional, informational technology, or business related problem-solving or school/ college improvement.	Critically analyzed the topic. Discussion of the topic was extensive and anchored in fact and reason. Information about significant aspects of the topic were analyzed from the perspective of key related concepts. Meaning of the analysis was summarized.	Critically analyzed the topic. Discussion of the topic was anchored in fact and reason. Information about significant aspects of the topic were analyzed from the perspective of key related concepts. Either the analysis or summary lacked some level of detail.	Somewhat critically analyzed the topic. Discussion of the topic was minimally anchored in fact and reason. Information about significant aspects of the topic were somewhat analyzed from the perspective of key related concepts. Analysis and summary included but lacks a significant level of analysis and discussion.	Minimally discussed the topic without supporting facts and reasons. Poor organization of the information and limited level of detail.
II. Consideration for the impact of leadership, information technology, or business on institutional constituents.	Demonstrates an extensive understanding of the topic's relationship to leadership, information technology, or business.	Demonstrates a good understanding of the topic's relationship to leadership, information technology, or business.	Demonstrates a fair understanding of the topic's relationship to leadership, information technology, or business.	Demonstrates a minimal understanding of the topic's relationship to leadership, information technology, or business.
III. Effective analytical and communication skills.	Demonstrates a professional level of skills associated with formatting, grammar, spelling, syntax, and use of numbers.	Demonstrates acceptable skills associated with formatting, grammar, spelling, syntax, and use of numbers.	Needs minor improvement in skills associated with formatting, grammar, spelling, syntax, and use of numbers.	Needs significant improvement in skills associated formatting, grammar, spelling, syntax, and use of numbers.
IV. Knowledge of genres, paradigms, theories or trends in business, criminal justice, education, English, health sciences, history, information technology, math, nursing, psychology, religion, or student personnel services.	Subject is identified, realistic, and grounded in a recognized genre, paradigm, theory, or trend.	Subject is identified and is realistic, but it lacks grounding in a recognized genre, paradigm, theory, or trend.	Subject is identified but is not realistic or grounded in a recognized genre, paradigm, theory, or trend.	Subject area is not established.
V. Required Components of Dissertation based on the Doctoral Research Handbook.	All required components are included for this portion of the dissertation based on the outline and requirements in the Doctoral Research handbook.	Minor information is missing from the required components for this portion of the dissertation based on the outline and requirements in the Doctoral Research handbook.	Significant information is missing from the required components for this portion of the dissertation based on the outline and requirements in the Doctoral Research handbook.	This portion of the dissertation lacks the detail needed to meet the requirements for the components outlined in the Doctoral Research handbook.

Dissertation Progress Rubric

	Proficient - 2	Meets - 1	No Progress - 0
Dissertation Progress	Clearly defined and realistic goals were set, and all goals were met during the semester.	Clearly defined and realistic goals were set, and 70% of goals were met this semester.	Goals were not set, or less than 70% of goals were met. Minimal or no progress was demonstrated.
Communication	The candidate met with the Chair at least every two weeks throughout the semester and provided updates on their progress by completing the journal entry in the course.	The candidate met with the Chair at least every three weeks throughout the semester and provided updates on their progress by completing the journal entry in the course.	The candidate had minimal contact or communication with the Chair and provided limited or no updates on their progress in the journals in the course.
Doctoral Research Processes	The guidelines in the Doctoral Research Handbook were followed along with all directions provided by the Chair.	The guidelines in the Doctoral Research Handbook and directions provided by the Chair were somewhat followed.	The guidelines in the Doctoral Research Handbook and directions provided by the Chair were not followed.

Appendix F: Quantitative Research Design

Quantitative Dissertations

The traditional quantitative dissertation follows a five-chapter format and a deductive approach. The required sections for the five chapters of the quantitative dissertation are located in Appendix A. While there is no set number of pages, quantitative research typically includes approximately 100 pages. This word requirement applies to the text of the dissertation only; it does not cover the title page, acknowledgments, table of contents, or other non-content related pages (UC Dissertation Handbook, 2024, p. 12).

In addition to the requirements for quantitative dissertation research as outlined in the *Dissertation Handbook*, quantitative dissertation studies must present **1)** clearly defined and operationalized study variables, **2)** data assumption tests aligned with statistical choices prior to hypothesis testing, and **3)** statistical tests aligned with research design choice. Descriptive analysis alone is not appropriate for dissertation research. Statistical tables must align with APA 7th ed. format.

The following are additional quality standards for the respective quantitative research designs allowed for UC dissertation research:

Quantitative Design	Rationale for Use	Additional Requirements
Nonexperimental Correlation	A nonexperimental correlation design is used to explore relationships between two or more variables through correlational analysis. The intent is to determine if and to what degree the variables are related. It does not imply influences for one variable upon another and does not include inferential regression analysis.	- Power analysis is required for minimum sample size. - Data assumptions must support parametric correlation; if not, appropriate nonparametric correlation is required. - Inclusion or exclusion of outliers must be justified. - Complete and report assumption checks for all inferential statistical analyses used. Assumption checks are required to ensure that the data meets the necessary conditions for valid and reliable results in hypothesis testing and model accuracy.
Predictive Correlation	A predictive correlation design is used to examine the predictive value of one or more predictor variables upon one or more criterion variables. Inferential regression analysis must be used but does not infer causation.	- Power analysis is required for minimum sample size. - Data assumptions must include normality, linearity, and homoscedasticity at a minimum. - Inclusion or exclusion of outliers must be justified. - Complete and report assumption checks for all inferential statistical analyses used. Assumption checks are required to ensure that the data meets the necessary conditions for valid and reliable results in hypothesis testing and model accuracy.
Comparative	Sometimes referred to as causal comparative or ex post facto design, a comparative design examines differences between variables with two or more groups/levels for one or more dependent variables. In comparative designs, the treatment or event has previously occurred.	- Power analysis is required for minimum sample size. - Group design description and rationale are required. - Homogenous groups are preferred. - Statistical tests must align with justified group/level design. - Complete and report assumption checks for all inferential statistical analyses used. Assumption checks are required to ensure that the data meets the necessary conditions for valid and reliable results in hypothesis testing and model accuracy.

Quasi-Experimental	A quasi-experimental design allows for a non-randomized treatment with pre-existing groups when a treatment/ intervention can be applied to one group and a control group exists in a natural setting. Therefore, random assignment of subjects is not used.	▪ Power analysis is required for minimum sample size ▪ Treatment/Intervention description and rationale are required. ▪ Equivalent groups are required. ▪ Nominal/categorical IV must be tested with continuous DV. ▪ Complete and report assumption checks for all inferential statistical analyses used. Assumption checks are required to ensure that the data meets the necessary conditions for valid and reliable results in hypothesis testing and model accuracy.
Experimental	An experimental design requires manipulation of one or more independent variables to assess the causal influence on one or more dependent variables. The experimental group receives the treatment/intervention, and the control group does not receive the treatment/intervention.	▪ Power analysis is required for minimum sample size. ▪ Random assignment of subjects is required. ▪ Treatment/Intervention description and rationale required. ▪ Complete and report assumption checks for all inferential statistical analyses used. Assumption checks are required to ensure that the data meets the necessary conditions for valid and reliable results in hypothesis testing and model accuracy.

Appendix G: Applied Research Design

APPLIED RESEARCH APPROACHES FOR DISSERTATION RESEARCH

Students who select the doctoral project will follow the Applied Research Option. This design extends or applies research through the development of a doctoral project for the DBA, EdD, and PhD programs. The applied research option, doctoral project, follows a four chapter format and may include software or IT tool development, business model, or educational program. The doctoral applied research project will use a systematic applied research approach to present a new tool, model, or program as determined through the literature review of existing items in the academic discipline. Candidates complete the Applied Research during professional research courses (DSRT 736, 839, 930, and 931), which are the last four courses taken during the program. There is no set number of pages due to the nature of the doctoral project (UC Dissertation Handbook, 2024, p.12).

In addition to the requirements for the applied dissertation research option outlined in the Dissertation Handbook, applied research studies must present 1) a research purpose to directly solve an immediate problem of practice as aligned with the program of study and/or area of specialization, 2) research questions designed to address the immediate problem and aligned with the applied research design, and 3) a study guided by a theoretical (or conceptual, if approved) framework. The use of a conceptual framework over a theoretical framework requires program director approval.

Applied Research Design	Rationale for Use	Additional Requirements
Action Research	Action research is a pragmatic method of inquiry aimed to make immediate positive change within a practice setting. An a priori power analysis will determine minimum sample size (medium effect).	- Power analysis must be used to determine minimum sample size - A well-defined and planned intervention must be included. - Two sources of data, one primary and one secondary, are required. - Must include post-intervention numeric data collection. - Appropriate action research data analysis method must be used.
Data Analytics	Sometimes referred to as text mining, machine learning, or deep learning, this research approach involves a systematic collection of a large data set for predictive or evaluative data-driven solutions to problems within a practice setting. May be combined as part of a design science project.	- Includes de-identified or researcher-generated data use only. - Requires appropriate predictive or evaluative data analyses. - Data visualization may be used to support solutions. - Artifact used for data mining and/or data generation and analysis must be illustrated within the study framework.
Design Science	Design science is a pragmatic, outcomes-based research approach used across information science for the development of technological artifacts to improve or offer solutions to real-world problems.	- Artifact development must be original and non-proprietary. - Project design must align with an established design science approach and can be inductive or deductive. - The artifact may be included in Chapter Four or an appendix.
Program Evaluation	Also referred to as evaluation research, this applied research approach involves a systematic evaluation of data gathered from a program, project, agency, or other organization with the goal of improvement.	- Systematic data collection defines multiple outputs for evaluation. - One of multiple outputs may include verbal data. - RQs must align with specific evaluation research approach.

Appendix H: Qualitative Research Design

QUALITATIVE APPROACHES FOR DISSERTATION RESEARCH

The qualitative dissertation should be approximately 45,000 words. This word requirement applies to the text of the dissertation only; it does not cover the title page, acknowledgment, table of contents, or other non-content-related pages. Thus, with a small indulgence in tautology, the dissertation should be as long as it needs to be, as long as it meets the minimum word requirements (UC Doctoral Research Handbook, 2024, p. 13).

In addition to the requirements for qualitative dissertation research, as outlined in the Doctoral Research Handbook, qualitative dissertation studies must present (a) a clearly defined and well-supported phenomenon of inquiry for the study, (b) data saturation, and rather than validity/reliability, (c) the four criteria for data trustworthiness must be evaluated in Chapter Four prior to presentation of findings: credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability. Theme Tables must align with APA 7th Ed. Format. Following are additional quality standards for the respective qualitative research approaches/designs allowed for UC Dissertation research.

Approach	Rationale for Use	Additional Requirements
Exploratory	Sometimes referred to as Descriptive, this approach is foundational when exploring a general phenomenon where prior insights are limited, and the aim is to gather new understanding or unearth initial concepts. Often used in the early stages of research to identify patterns or areas for further study.	- Data: Requires at least two data sources. - Primary Requirement: Individual interviews with 10-12 participants. - Secondary Options: Choose one from the following as a second data source: open-ended questionnaires, archival sources, relevant documents, ethnography, focus groups, or structured observations.
Case Study	Suitable for in-depth exploration of a case (or multiple cases) in a specific context. Case studies offer rich detail and complexity about a real-life situation or phenomenon, making them ideal for research requiring close examination of a bounded system. Whether single or multiple cases, the unit of analysis must be consistently defined and applied.	- Three sources of data are required (Triangulation), with one source possibly including numeric data. - First Source: Individual interviews with 10-12 participants or a minimum of three focus group interviews (3 participants each). - Second Source: Ethnographic or structured observations required. - Third Source Options: Open-ended questionnaires, archival documents, or other relevant materials. - Data analysis method must align with the case study for the field of study (expectations may differ among program areas).
Narrative Inquiry	Appropriate when the study explores a unified lifelong experience, capturing personal stories over a long period (typically 20+ years). This approach is valuable for understanding how individuals make sense of their experiences over time. <i>*Keep in mind that this must be a lifelong (20+ years) experience otherwise, the lived experience is a phenomenological study.</i>	- Minimum of one data source required. - Primary Requirement: Individual interviews with 8-10 participants focused on the lifelong experience. - Narrative interviews as data source: Can be structured, unstructured, or semi-structured. - Optional: Additional sources may be included but are not mandatory. - Narrative data analysis method must be used. - Findings may be presented as narrative vignettes.

Phenomenology • Descriptive • Interpretive (Hermeneutic)	Phenomenology is ideal for studying the essence of deeply held lived experiences, capturing how individuals experience a particular phenomenon. Descriptive phenomenology focuses on eliminating researcher bias, while interpretive phenomenology acknowledges the influence of interpretation. Interpretative phenomenological analysis (IPA) can also be applied within a hermeneutic or as a standalone design. Other Advanced Phenomenological Approaches: • Transcendental Phenomenology (Descriptive) • Hermeneutic Circle (Interpretive)	▪ At least one data source is required. ▪ Primary Requirement: Individual interviews with 12-15 participants or at least four focus group interviews (3 participants each). ▪ In-depth, unstructured, or semi-structured interviews. ▪ Optional: Other sources can be included for further depth but are not required. ▪ Data analysis method must align with the specific type of phenomenology used. ▪ Synthesis of participant experiences required.
Grounded Theory	Best used when the goal is to develop new theories or models to explain a phenomenon. This approach involves iterative data collection and analysis to build a theoretical framework grounded in participant experiences. Classic, traditional, or constructivist grounded theory may be used.	▪ Minimum of one data source required. ▪ Primary Requirements: Theoretical sampling and Iterative individual interviews with 12-15 participants or a minimum of four focus group interviews (3 participants each). ▪ Optional: Additional sources may be used to complement the primary data. ▪ Strong rationale for new theory or model for the phenomenon of inquiry within the field of study required. ▪ Grounded theory-aligned data analysis method must be used.
Delphi Study	The Delphi approach is used to achieve a consensus among a panel of experts through structured, iterative rounds of data collection. It is ideal for forecasting trends, identifying best practices, or generating new ideas.	▪ One Source of Data Minimum ▪ Iterative data collection with a focus on reaching consensus. ▪ The sample should be diverse and representative of the relevant population or field of study. ▪ Justification of the sample size and selection criteria must be included. ▪ Primary Requirement: Iterative individual interviews or focus groups, or 30+ participants using iterative open-ended questionnaires. ▪ Panel Size: Minimum of 10-15 experts. ▪ Number of experts on the panel required will depend on the research questions, the level of consensus desired, and the concept of saturation. ▪ Data saturation should be utilized in recruiting expert panel members until a point of saturation is reached. ▪ Other sources can be included, but they are not required.

Historical Leadership	Historiography is applied to understand past events, societies, or individuals within their historical context. This approach emphasizes the critical interpretation of historical sources (historical documents, artifacts, records, oral histories, personal diaries, photographs, and other primary sources), providing a nuanced account of leadership phenomena over time.	▪ Relies primarily on historical documents, artifacts, and other primary sources. ▪ Primary Requirement: Triangulation through multiple sources is crucial to cross-verify findings is essential for ensuring the validity of the research. ▪ Analysis: Critical evaluation of sources, including credibility and bias, is essential. ▪ The requirements for the analysis may vary depending on the nature of the study but may include content analysis, discourse analysis, thematic analysis, or grounded theory, among others. ▪ Analysis involves constructing a narrative that provides a comprehensive, nuanced account of the past. ▪ Large reference list required.
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